

COLOSSIANS

THE

EPISTLE OF S. PAUL, THE APOSTLE,

TO THE COLOSSIANS.

PREFACE.

Colosse was a city of Phrygia, near Laodicea. It does not appear that S. Paul had preached there himself, (see C. ii. 1.) but that the Colossians were converted by Epaphras, a disciple of the apostles. However, as S. Paul was the great apostle of the Gentiles, he wrote this epistle to the Colossians when he was in prison, and about the same time that he wrote to the Ephesians and Philippians. The exhortations and doctrine it contains, are similar to those which are set forth in his epistle to the Ephesians. S. Chrys. takes notice, that the epistles he wrote in prison seem even more spiritual than the rest: the chief design of which was to hinder them from being seduced by false teachers. Ch. Wi. — The Colossians were first instructed in the faith by Epaphras, who is considered their first bishop. He was a prisoner, at Rome, with S. Paul, when this epistle was written. The intent of it was to disabuse the Colossians of worshipping the Angels; for Cerinthus and others, had taught them to look upon Angels as superior to Christ, whom they looked upon as a mere man; to observe the law of Moses, with all its legal rites and ceremonies.

He begins his epistle by insisting chiefly on the exalted state of Christ, saying that he is the image of the invisible God, the first-born of every creature, by whom all things visible and invisible were created, whether thrones, principalities, or powers, and that in him the divinity essentially exists. From this he proves the inutility of the ceremonies of the law, &c. (Fleury and Calmet) and takes great pains to prevent their relapsing either into paganism or Judaism. V.

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COLOSSIANS 1

CHAPTER I.

Ver. 6. In the whole world; i.e. a great part of it. Wi. — This epistle was written in the year 62, at which time the gospel had spread itself through the whole world by the preaching not only of the apostles, but of their disciples, and by the noise which this new religion made. Calmet. — S. Austin sheweth with S.

Paul, that the Church and Christ's gospel was to grow daily, and to spread all over the world; which cannot stand with what heretics allude of the failure of the Church, nor with their own obscure conventicles. ep. lxxx. ad finem.

Ver. 7. Of Epaphras, who seems to have been their first apostle, and their bishop. Wi.

Ver. 8. Your love. Your charity for all men, founded on the love of God. Others understand it of the affection which they had for S. Paul. S. Chrys.

Ver. 9. In all wisdom. He begins by an admonition against false teachers, who it is likely, says S. Chrys. with their philosophical notions mixed errors and fables. Wi.

Ver. 10. Worthy of God: axios tou kuriou. So S. Ambrose and the Greek doctors; or thus, worthily, pleasing God, and this not by faith only, but fruitful in every good work. Ibid. — God, in[1] all things pleasing him. This is the construction of the Latin by the Greek. Wi.

Ver. 14. It is through the blood of Christ, and not by the law of Moses, that we are freed from the power of death. If the law could have saved us, the coming of Christ would have been useless. See then, he says, if it be proper to engage under a law which is so inefficacious. Calmet. — From this verse and from v.

12, et alibi passim, we are taught that we are not only by imputation made partakers of Christ's benefits, but are by his grace made worthy thereof, and deserve our salvation condignly, ex condigno. B.

Ver. 15. The first[2] born of every creature. S. Chrys. takes notice against the Arians, that the apostle calls Christ the first-begotten, or first-born, not the first created, because he was not created at all. And the sense is, that he was before all creatures, proceeding from all eternity from the Father; though some expound the words of Christ as man, and that he was greater in dignity. See Rom. viii. 29. Wi.

Ver. 16. Thrones, &c. are commonly understood to refer to the celestial hierarchy of Angels, though as to their particular rank, &c. nothing certain is known. We may here observe, that the Holy Spirit proportions itself and speaks according to our ideas of a temporal kingdom, in which one authority is subject to another. In the same manner the Angels seem subordinate to one another. S. Dionysius in Calmet. — All things were created by him, and in him, and [3]consist in him. If all things that are were made by him, he himself was not made. And his divine power is also signified, when it is said all things consist or are preserved by him. Wi.

Ver. 18. He is the head of the body, the church. He now speaks of what applies to Christ as man. — The first-born from the dead; i.e. the first that rose to an immortal life. Wi.

Ver. 19. In him it was pleasing, that all fulness should dwell.[4] The greatest plenitude of graces was conferred on him as man, and from him, as he was our head, derived to all the members of his Church. The Prot. translation, followed by Mr. N. by way of explanation adds, it hath pleased the Father; but, as Dr.

Wells observes in his paraphrase, there is no reason to restrain it to the Father, seeing the work of the incarnation, and the blessings by it conferred on all mankind, are equally the work of the blessed Trinity, though the Second Person only was joined to our nature. Wi.

Ver. 20. To reconcile all things unto himself, . . . through the blood of his cross, (i.e. which Christ shed on the cross) both as to the things on earth, and . . . in heaven: not that Christ died for the Angels, but, says S. Chrys. the Angels were in a manner at war with men, with sinners, as they stood for the cause and glory of God; but Christ put an end to this enmity, by restoring men to his favour. Wi. — In heaven. Not by pardoning the wicked angels did Christ reconcile the things in heaven, but by reconciling good Angels to man, who were enemies to him before the birth of Christ. S. Austin.

Ver. 24. And fill up those things . . . in my flesh for his body, which is the church.[5] Nothing was wanting in the sufferings or merits of Christ, for a sufficient and superabundant redemption of mankind, and therefore he adds, for his body, which is the church, that his sufferings were wanting, and are to be endured by the example of Christ by the faithful, who are members of a crucified head. See S. Chrys. and S. Aug. Wi. — Wanting. There is no want in the sufferings of Christ himself as head; but many sufferings are still wanting, or are still to come in his body, the Church, and his members, the faithful. Ch.

— S. Chrysostom here observes that Jesus Christ loves us so much, that he is not content merely to suffer in his own person, but he wishes also to suffer in his members; and thus we fill up what is wanting of the sufferings of Christ. S.

Chrys. — The wisdom, the will, the justice of Jesus Christ, requireth and ordaineth that his body and members should be companions of his sufferings, as they expect to be companions of his glory; that so suffering with him, and after his example, they may apply to their own wants and to the necessities of others the merits and satisfaction of Jesus Christ, which application is what is wanting, and what we are permitted to supply by the sacraments and sacrifice of the new law.

Ver. 25. According to the dispensation of God; i.e. to the appointment of his divine providence. Wi.

Ver. 26. The mystery of Christ's incarnation, which hath been hidden, &c. See Ephes. i. 12. and v. 4, &c. Wi.

[1] V. 10. Ut ambuletis dignè Deo per omnia placentes; axios tou Kuriou eis pasan areskeian.

[2] V. 15. Primogenitus omnis creaturæ; prototokos pases ktiseos. S. Chrys.

log. g. p. 103. ou protoktistos, alla prototokos . . . oukoun ektistai.

[3] V. 16. In ipso constant; en auto sunesteke. See S. Chrys.

[4] V. 19. In ipso complacuit. We may rather understand Deo than Patri. So S.

Chrys. p. 105. ten thelesin tou Theou, touto gar estin oti en auto endokese.

[5] V. 24. Adimpleo quæ desunt; ta usteremata. See S. Chrys. and S. Aug. in Ps.

lxxxvi. tom. 4. p. 922. B. restabant Christi passiones in corpore, vos autem estis Christi Corpus, et membra. Vide S. Chrys. om. d. p. 109.

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COLOSSIANS 2

CHAPTER II.

Ver. 4. That no man may deceive you.[1] He means those false teachers and vain philosophers, who deceived them by a sophistical way of reasoning, advancing in this manner their fabulous inventions; it is likely some disciples of Simon the magician. Wi. — The false teachers whom S. Paul wished to refute, despising the doctrine of the gospel, which appeared too simple and common, affected mysterious discourses, and examined the doctrine of the apostles, according to the maxims and axioms of philosophers. They also denied that Christ was God. Tirinus. — May not this advice be at present applicable to many

of our Christian brethren, who are but too often led away by trusting too much to the vain reasonings of man. A.

Ver. 7. Rooted and built up in him, who is the head of all, your Redeemer, and author of your salvation, not upon Angels. Wi.

Ver. 8. Lest any man impose upon you.[2] In the Greek, make a prey of you, as thieves that steal things. — There were two sorts of false teachers among them; they who mixed vain errors from heathen philosophy with the principles of the Christian religion, and they who had been Jews, and were for making them retain those rites and customs which the Jews had among them, and were only from their private human traditions. Wi. This alludes to the traditions and observances which the Pharisees had added to the law of Moses, and which Christ had blamed; but which these false apostles wished to introduce amongst the Colossians. The ceremonial laws were the elementary instructions given by God to the world, but we are to attach ourselves to the doctrines of Jesus Christ, from whom alone we expect light and justice, and sanctity. V. — According to the rudiments of the world: by which some expound vain fallacies and false maxims of the first kind of teachers; others the Jewish ceremonies, which are called weak and poor elements, or rudiments. Gal. iv. 9. This is neither to condemn in general the use of philosophy, which S. Aug. commends, and made use of, nor all traditions delivered by the apostles. See 1 Cor. xi. and 2. Thess. ii. 14. Wi.

Ver. 9. For in him (in Christ) dwelleth all the fulness of the Godhead (of the divinity) corporally.[3] That is, in the person of Christ, the Son of God, really and substantially united to our human nature. Not inhabiting, as in a temple as the Nestorian heretics pretended, nor as by his grace in men's souls, but so as to be personally or hypostatically united to the soul and body of Christ. Wi.

Ver. 12. Buried with him in baptism, signified by the ceremony of immersion in baptism. See Rom. vi. 3. Wi.

Ver. 14. Blotting out, &c.[4] This is commonly expounded of the sentence of eternal death pronounced against sinful Adam, and all his

posterity, for having sinned in him. Others would have it to signify only the yoke and obligations of the Mosaic law, which could not of itself remit sins, and occasionally made persons greater sinners. This sentence of death (whether we understand the one or the other) Christ took away, fastening it as it were, to the cross, taking it away by his death on the cross. Wi.

Ver. 15. And despoiling the principalities and powers; the devil and his infernal spirits. Wi.

Ver. 16. Let no man, therefore, judge you in meat or in drink. That is, for not abstaining from meats, called unclean, for drinking out of a cup without a cover, (see Num. xix.) or for not keeping the Jewish festivals. For these were but shadows, types and figures of future things to be fulfilled in the new law of Christ: but the body is of Christ, (v. 17.) i.e. was the body, the truth, the substance signified by these shadows and types. Wi. — He means with regard to the Jewish observations of the distinction of clean and unclean meats; and of their festivals, new moons, and sabbaths; as being no longer obligatory. Ch.

— Modern dogmatizers wilfully or ignorantly misapply this text of the apostle, to disprove the fasts and festivals observed in the Catholic Church; but it is evident, as S. Austin observes, that the apostle is here condemning the legal distinction of clean and unclean meats, and the feasts of the new moon, to which false brethren wanted to subject the Colossians. S. Aug. ep. 59. ad Paulin. in solut. quæ. 7.

Ver. 18. Let no man seduce you.[5] In the Greek, hinder you from getting the prize. — Willing[6] (by their own will) in humility, and religion of Angels, practising a wrong and mistaken humility in regard of the Angels, when you pay them a worship not due to them, pretending them to be the mediators and saviours of mankind, as if they were equal, or greater than Christ, our only Redeemer; walking in things you understand not, these men being deceived by their vain philosophy, and pride of their own imaginations. By this means not holding, (v. 19.) but having shaken off their only true invisible head, Christ Jesus, who is the head of his Church. It is admitted that these false doctors, among the Colossians, had introduced an undue and

superstitious worship of Angels, and gave to them even a greater honour than to Christ. They worshipped them as the creators of the world, as mediators with God, even above Jesus Christ, which S. Paul here expresseth by these words, not holding the head. These seem to have been some disciples of Simon, and their heresies continued in some churches of Asia even to the fourth age, as we may find by a canon of the council of Laodicea. But there is nothing here nor in that council against a due, i.e. an inferior honour and veneration, nothing like a divine honour, nor injurious to Christ, our chief mediator and only Redeemer, which the Church, from the first ages, paid to saints and Angels.

We do not ask grace, we do not offer up sacrifice, we hope not for salvation, but from God only, from Christ, God and man. Wi. — Willing, &c. That is, by a self-willed, self-invented, superstitious worship, falsely pretending humility, but really proceeding from pride. Such was the worship that many of the philosophers (against whom S. Paul speaks, v. 8.) paid to Angels or demons, by sacrificing to them, as carriers of intelligence betwixt God and man; pretending humility in so doing, as if God was too great to be addressed by men, and setting aside the mediatorship of Jesus Christ; who is the head both of Angels and men. Such also was the worship paid by the ancient heretics, disciples of Simon and Menander, to the Angels, whom they believed to be the makers and lords of this lower world. This is certain, that they whom the apostle here condemns, did not hold the head, (v. 19.) that is, Jesus Christ, and his mediatorship; and therefore what he writes here no ways touches the Catholic doctrine and practice, of desiring our good Angels to pray to God for us, through Jesus Christ. S. Jerom, (Epist. ad Algas) understands by the religion or service of Angels, the Jewish religion given by Angels; and shews all that is here said to be directed against the Jewish teachers, who sought to subject the new Christians to the observances of the Mosaic law. Ch. —

Walking in the things which he hath not seen. These false teachers pretended to know the number and names of the Angels, and how to distribute them into different orders and classes, with as much precision as if they had walked through heaven. Instead of following

the revelation of the holy Spirit in the gospel, they followed their own spirit, boasting of what it was impossible for them to know. C. — But let no one snatch from you the glory of heaven, which should be the reward of your career, and the recompense of your fidelity, deceiving you by an outward show of false piety and affected humility. V.

Ver. 20. If then you be dead with Christ, or if you be not of this world, why do you act as if you were in it? practising the ceremonies of the law, as if you still expected Christ; all which are hurtful to you. S. Jerom. — In your baptism you died with Jesus Christ to all legal observances, and should not therefore suffer any carnal laws to be imposed upon you, as if you were still living in this first state of the world. V. — These things have an appearance of humility, if you abstain from them through mortification, and not through any necessity, as if they were unclean. But if we look upon them, and reject them as impure, and despise those who do not follow our example, then these things, so far from being useful, become prejudicial. Grotius. — Why do you yet decree[7] in this manner? Wi.

Ver. 21. Touch not, &c. That is, why do you permit yourselves to be taught in this manner by those Jewish doctors: why do you touch or eat this, lest you be unclean? such superstitious observations, now at least, when there is no necessity nor obligation for you to observe them, tend to destruction, &c. Wi.

— The meaning is, that Christians should not subject themselves, either to the ordinances of the old law, forbidding touching or tasting things unclean: or to the superstitious invention of heretics, imposing such restraints, under pretence of wisdom, humility, or mortification. Ch.

Ver. 23. Which things have indeed, (as such masters teach you) a shew of wisdom, in their nice superstitious ways, joined by some of them with extraordinary abstinences, and severities practised on the body in fasting, which they observe, without any honour or regard, even not to the satiating of the flesh; i.e. according to the common expression, with such an excess, as not to allow the body[8] what is sufficient or necessary to support nature, that a man may be able to labour and

comply with his duties; but here is nothing against discreet fasting, and self-denials, so much recommended in the holy Scriptures. Wi.

[1] V. 4. Decipiat, paralogizetai, fallaci ratiocinatione.

[2] V. 8. Decipiat, sulagogon, prædam furtive abducens. See S. Chrys. log. st.

p. 118.

[3] V. 9. In ipso inhabitat omnis plenitudo divinitatis corporaliter, katoi kai pan to pleroma tes theotetos somatikos. See S. Chrys. Ibid.

[4] V. 14. Chirographum decreti; cheirographon tou dogmatos. In the common Greek copies, tois dogmasi, as Ephes. ii. 15.

[5] V. 18. Seducat, katabrabeueto. See Mr. Legh's Crit. Sacra.

[6] Ibid. Volens, thelon; religione, threskeia. — Walking, ambulans, embateuon, superbè se ingerens.

[7] V. 20. Quid adhuc decernitis, dogmatizesthe.

[8] V. 23. Et non ad parcendum corpori, kai apheidia somatos, et in non parentia corporis, vel in crudelitate erga corpus. — Non in honore ad saturitatem, ouk en time pros plesmonen.

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COLOSSIANS 3

CHAPTER III.

Ver. 1. Here begins the second or the moral part of this epistle. — If you be risen, &c. The remaining part of this epistle has no great difficulties, but excellent instructions, as that to the Ephesians. Wi.

Ver. 5. Your members, . . . fornication, uncleanness, &c. He considers man's body as made up of sins and sinful inclinations. Wi. — It is not to bring back Judaism we practise abstinences and fasts, nor with the same motive as the Jews, but to accomplish the precepts of mortifying the irregular desires of the flesh among which gluttony must find a place. In a mortified body sensuality is more easily subdued. A.

Ver. 6. The children of unbelief are either those who perished in Noe's flood, for S. Peter in his epistle give them this title, or they are the inhabitants of Chanaan, whom Josue exterminated; for these also are called children of unbelief, in the epistle to the Hebrews, and their crimes were the same as those mentioned here. Calmet.

Ver. 8. Blasphemy.[1] It may here signify either the sin of blasphemy against God, or speaking ill of our neighbour by detraction, calumnies, affronts, &c.

See S. Chrys. Wi. — Now that you live in God, with Jesus Christ, quit not only the above shameful crimes, but also these sins, which, although they excite less horror, will separate you no less from the Author of all sanctity.

Ver. 10. According to the image of him who created him. We are created to the image of God, inasmuch as our souls are spiritual and immortal, but here we are put in mind to imitate God by sanctity and justice, as God is holy and the fountain of justice. Wi. — The image or resemblance of our Creator was effaced by sin, but is retraced by Jesus Christ, who forms in us this new man.

V.

Ver. 11. Where, or in which state, when we put on the new man by sanctity and grace, God makes no distinction betwixt Jew and Gentile, &c. Wi. — In the Church of Christ God makes no exception of persons; all are called to the marriage feast, whether Jews (formerly the most favoured people of God) or Greeks, (who were reckoned the most polite, or learned) or Barbarians, or Scythians: (who are esteemed the most cruel and ferocious of men) still these are called; Christ died for

all. Calmet. — In S. Paul's epistles, by the Greeks are usually designated the Gentiles. V.

Ver. 14. Above all these things have charity, the love of God, and of your neighbour, which is the bond of perfection, the end of all virtues, which unites the hearts of all to God. Wi.

Ver. 15. The peace of Christ rejoice:[2] reign, conquer, bear away the prize. Wi.

Ver. 16. Employ yourselves in studying and reading the Scriptures; meditate on what our Saviour has done and suffered for you. It is a calumny of our enemies, that we forbid the reading of the Testament. But the Church, fearing lest the faithful should read to their own destruction what was ordained for their salvation, wisely ordains that they should have recourse to their pastors, and receive from them those versions which she approves as most conformable to the Latin Vulgate, which has received the sanction of the holy Catholic Church, and at the same time forbids them those which might corrupt their faith. In this she acts the part of a good and provident mother, conducting her children to the rich and salutary pastures of peace and plenty, and carefully guarding them from others where tempting but noxious weeds luxuriantly grow up, watered with the baneful streams of polluted and poisoned sources.

If pure be the steams from the fountain,

As purely the river will flow;

If noxious the stream from the mountain,

It poisons the valley below.

Ver. 17. Do all in the name of the Lord Jesus Christ. Let all be done for his honour and glory. See 1 Cor. x. 31. Wi.

[1] V. 8. Blasphemiam. S. Chrys. p. 133. blasthemias, tas loidoriai.

[2] V. 15. Exultet, brabeueto, palmam referat.

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COLOSSIANS 4

CHAPTER IV.

Ver. 1. Masters should remember that they also have a Master to whom they must reckon, and from whom they must expect the same justice they measure out to others.

Ver. 3. A door of speech; i.e. of free speech to preach the gospel. Wi.

Ver. 5. Redeeming the time. This expression occurs also in the epistle to the Ephesians, and seems to insinuate to the faithful to be on their guard not to irritate the Gentiles, nor to provoke them to persecution. Remember, says he, the times are bad; conduct yourselves with prudence; gain time, procure peace, and remain in silence. This was written towards the end of the reign of Nero, as cruel a prince as ever lived. C.

Ver. 10. The same as John and Mark mentioned in the Acts, xv. 37, 39.

Ver. 12. Epaphras. He was apostle and bishop of the Colossians, as has been observed. It was he who engaged S. Paul to write to them, fearing lest they should give themselves up to the novelties of the false apostles, after having received the gospel from him in all its purity. C.

Ver. 16. Read you that which is of the Laodiceans.[1] Some expound these words of an epistle which S. Paul wrote to the Laodiceans, which is lost, for that now extant is no more than a collection of sentences out of S. Paul. By the Greek text is rather signified a letter writ from Laodicea, and might be a letter sent from the Laodiceans to S. Paul, which he had a mind the Colossians should read. Wi. — This opinion does not, however, seem well founded. Hence it is more probable, that

S. Paul wrote an epistle from Rome to the Laodiceans about the same time that he wrote to the Colossians, as he had them both equally at heart, and that he ordered that epistle to be read by the Colossians for their instruction; and, being neighbouring cities, they might communicate to each other what they had received from him: as one epistle might contain some matters not related in the other, and would be equally useful for their concern; and more particularly as they were equally disturbed by intruders and false teachers, against whom the apostle was anxious to warn them, lest they should be infected by their pernicious doctrine. Ch. — It is the most common opinion, both amongst the ancients and moderns, that the epistle here alluded to was one written by the Laodiceans to S. Paul, which he sent to Colossus with this, and not one which he himself had written to the Laodiceans. It is however now lost. This exposition agrees best with the Greek. Calmet.

Ver. 17. What S. Paul here addresses to Archippus, gives us reason to presume that he was then bishop of the Colossians, having succeeded Epaphras, who was then prisoner at Rome with S. Paul. V.

[1] V. 16. That of the Laodiceans. Eam quæ Laodicensium est, ten ek Laodikeias. See S. Crys. (log. ib. p. 152.) and P. Mauduit dissert. on this place, who endeavours to prove that S. Paul wrote to the Laodiceans.

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